

Magna Carta. It was their historic defense of a basic human right: "the establishment of regular commissions."

This Buttonwood Agreement was apparently signed on May 17, 1792. The brokers were greatly relieved. From there, they moved away from the outdoor flea market under the sycamore tree in front of 68–70 Wall Street, and occupied several temporary indoor homes. In 1863, the present New York Stock Exchange was opened for business. In 1867, the first tickers were installed, and on December 15, 1886, the Exchange had its first million-share day.

Before I finished taking notes on all this, I suffered the additional curses from more impatient people stuck behind me, as two or three more subways disgorged hundreds of additional passengers carrying *Wall Street Journals*. Finally I joined the crowd, which launched me up the stairs and onto the cold sidewalk.

If you've seen the TV advertisement where the investor stands here alone at the crack of dawn, anxious to get the jump on his competitors, then you already know that the much ballyhooed Wall Street is actually a narrow, crooked way. I'm told that there once was an actual wall, built to hold off wolves, raiders, or any other enemies who might attempt an unfriendly takeover. Such protection is no longer necessary and the wall has long since been removed. From today's investment news, you'd think that all the raiders, wolves, and enemies who attempt unfriendly takeovers have been absorbed into the regular business routine.

At one end of the crooked way is the Trinity Church and graveyard, at the other end the East River, and in between the financial masses scurry to work, pressed briefcase-to-briefcase like rival thoroughbreds squeezed at the eighth pole. I wondered how many old college friends were among them, people I once chided for wanting to be rich instead of happy, now earning \$350,000 plus per year and not demonstrably the worse for it. I read in the paper that one such old friend, John Brim, was named a managing partner of Salomon Brothers, the huge and powerful investment house right up the street. If only I'd sent a few Christmas cards or kept up some contact, at least I'd have an excuse to pick his million-dollar brain.

As it was, my first Wall Street contact was with Anatoli, who runs the candy stand outside the New York Stock Exchange build-